



Ten questions to ask at the table

For Rosh Hashanah, or for any table where three generations sit down at once.

Put your phone on the table and press record before the soup comes out. Do not make it an interview. Ask one question and let everyone talk over each other, because that is where the good parts are. Say the date and who is at the table at the start, so that in thirty years somebody knows.

- 1 What was the town called then, and who else in the family came from there?**
Say it the way they say it, however they spell it. What it is called today is the easy part to find later.
- 2 Who else lived in that house?**
The answer is almost always more people than anyone expects.
- 3 Why did they leave, in what year, and who stayed behind?**
Nobody has ever left for only one reason.
- 4 Where did they go first?**
Almost nobody arrives straight at the place they ended up.
- 5 Who was the troublemaker of that generation?**
There is exactly one per generation, and it is never the one you would guess.
- 6 Who married someone the family disapproved of, and how long did the disapproval last?**
In a good many families the honest answer to the second half is that it is still going.
- 7 What did we change on the way: the name, the language, the profession, the country? And who decided?**
- 8 What dish does nobody make any more, and who still has it in their head?**
Write this one down before the coffee. It is the one that always gets lost.
- 9 Go round the table. Which relative from your childhood do you remember best, and why?**
Then ask the opposite. Which one does nobody remember, and who was the last person to see them?
- 10 Go round the table again. Every person tells the one family story they remember best.**
You find out very quickly which stories get told every single year, and who tells them wrong.

AND ONE MORE, IF THE EVENING IS GOING WELL

Is there a photograph nobody can name?

Put it on the table while all the people who might know are still in the room.

Ten minutes is enough. Every family has a document nobody can read and a town whose name changed twice, and the people who could have explained both were sitting at the table the whole time.

שנה טובה

A Family Story Map turns a family memoir, or a folder of documents and photographs, into an interactive map. Every place opens your own photograph and the part of the story that belongs to it.

ludara.ai/familystorymap